AI Innovation Challenge

Pre-Summit Event,

(Under Consideration by IndiaAI)

India–AI Impact Summit 2026

National PARAM Supercomputing Facility

Centre for Development of Advanced Computing

A Scientific Society of Ministry of Electronics & Information Technology, Government of India

Innovation Park, Panchavati, Pashan Road, Pune – 411008

1.1 Overview

The AI Innovation Challenge is being organized as a Pre-Summit Event to the India–AI Impact Summit 2026 (this event is under Consideration as a Pre-Summit Event by IndiaAI), by the National PARAM Supercomputing Facility (NPSF), C-DAC, Pune.

The AI Innovation Challenge is envisaged as a platform to encourage innovators and researchers to design, build, train, and test practical AI solutions for real-world problems. It invites startups, MSMEs, academia, research organizations, PSUs, and individual innovators to develop and showcase AI-driven solutions aligned with National and Regional priorities in the domains of defined thematic areas of Generative AI, Natural Language Processing, AI for Science, and Emerging Technologies, leveraging the AIRAWAT AI Supercomputing Platform. (For more details about AIRAWAT, please visit https://airawat.cdac.in)

Shortlisted participants will receive free access to AIRAWAT's GPU resources and system/application-level support to develop their proposed use cases. The top three winning teams will be recognized with cash prizes and extended GPU compute credits to further enhance and demonstrate their solutions for real-world deployment.

1.1.1 Thematic Areas:

The Innovation Challenge invites proposals addressing one or more (multidisciplinary) of the following key thematic areas:

1. **Generative AI (GenAI):** India-centric foundation models and multimodal generative solutions for language, vision, and design, driving enterprise and governance applications aligned with the IndiaAI Mission.

2. **Natural Language Processing (NLP):** AI models for multilingual understanding, conversational systems, and translation of Indian languages, in alignment with *Mission Bhashini*.

3. **AI for Science:** AI-driven innovation in computational biology, materials science, drug discovery, climate modelling, and scientific

simulations leveraging AI-HPC infrastructure.

4. **Emerging Technologies:** AI integration in Robotics, Physical AI, and Quantum Computing for next-generation intelligent systems and others.

1.2 Stages

The AI Innovation Challenge will be conducted in three stages:

1. Stage 1 – Proposal Submission and Screening

Duration: 31 October 2025 – 6 November 2025

- Participants will register and submit proposals through the Google Form Link, detailing the problem statement, proposed AI approach, and resource needs.
- Proposals will be reviewed by experts from C-DAC, academia, and industry based on innovation, feasibility, scalability, and societal impact.
- **Outcome:** Shortlisted teams will be announced.

2. Stage 2 – Solution Development and Testing

Duration: 8 November 2025 – 27 November 2025

- Shortlisted teams will receive free GPU compute credits on AIRAWAT to develop and test their AI solutions.
- Teams must submit final code, documentation, and a demo video by the deadline.

3. Stage 3 –Presentation and Awards

Dates: 4–5 December 2025

- Finalists will present their solutions at an event organized by C-DAC.
- The top three teams will be rewarded with cash prizes, free GPU

compute credits, and certificates.

- Travel and accommodation support(1/2 representatives) to the final event will be provided, and the details will be communicated to the respective team leaders.

1.3 Timeline

Si.no.	Stage	Dates
1.	**Stage 1: - Registration & Proposal Submission**	31 October 2025 – 6 November 2025
2.	**Evaluation & Shortlisting of Proposals**	6–7 November 2025
3.	**Stage 2: - Solution Development and Testing Phase**	8 November 2025 – 27 November 2025
4.	**Submission of the Solution**	27 November 2025
5.	**Solution Evaluation & Shortlisting for Final Event**	28 November – 3 December 2025
6.	**Stage 3:- Proposed Event & Demonstration (C-DAC Pune)**	To be announced (tentatively on 4-5 December)
7.	**Final Results & Awards Ceremony**	To be announced (tentatively on 4-5 December)

1.4 Eligibility Criteria

1. **Open Participation:**
   The AI Innovation Challenge is open to all eligible entities and individuals across India, including startups, MSMEs, academia, research institutions, public sector organizations, and individual innovators.

2. **Indian Entity Requirement:**
   All participating organizations must be registered in India and comply with applicable Indian laws.
- Companies must be registered under the **Companies Act, 2013** or a relevant State/UT Act.
- Section 8 or non-profit entities must provide valid registration certificates.
- Academic or research institutions must submit authorization from their Head of Institution or equivalent.
3. **Startups & MSMEs:**
- Must be **DPIIT-recognized** and Indian-owned (≥51% Indian shareholding).
- Should be engaged in AI, data science, or digital innovation-related activities.
4. **Academic & Research Participants:**
- Faculty, researchers, or students from recognized institutions (IITs, NITs, IIITs, universities, or research labs) can participate individually or as teams.
- Academic teams may collaborate with startups or industry partners.
5. **Public Sector & Section 8 Entities:**
- PSUs, government R&D organizations, and non-profits working in innovation may participate independently or in collaboration.
6. **Individual Innovators:**
- Indian citizens aged 18 years or above can participate individually or form teams.
- If affiliated with an organization, participants must provide a **No Objection Certificate (NOC)** from their employer.
7. **Team Composition:**
- Teams may include **1–5 members**.
- One **Team Leader** must be nominated for all communications.
- Unregistered teams may participate but must register as a legal entity if selected for final submission

1.5 Rules & Guidelines

1. All teams must meet the eligibility criteria to participate.
2. Individuals associated with organizations must submit an NOC clarifying IP and prize rights.
3. The compute access provided via AIRAWAT shall only be used for AI solution development related to this challenge.

4. Winners will retain full rights to their developed solution, subject to adherence to challenge terms.
5. Solutions must be original and not infringe upon existing IP, copyrights, or patents.
6. All solutions must comply with data governance, privacy, and cybersecurity guidelines issued by the Government of India.
7. The winning teams shall ensure continued technical support and maintenance of their solution for a minimum of 2 years.
8. Ethical AI principles — fairness, transparency, accountability, and non-discrimination — must be followed throughout development.
9. All decisions made by the Evaluation Committee or any other designated authority / committee regarding shortlisting, evaluation, final selection and any other related matter shall be final and binding on all participants.
10. Participants are solely responsible for the data they upload, process, or generate during the challenge. C-DAC/NPSF will not be responsible for any data loss or unauthorized access. Participants should maintain necessary backups.

1.6 Registration Process

The registration and proposal submission process will be carried out entirely through an online Google Form. The registration process will consist of three sequential stages, as detailed below:

1.6.1. Participation in Initial Submission and Screening

I. Participants can register and submit their proposals using the designated Google Form link.

Link:** ***https://forms.gle/uzS9GBEXaK31mzgB8

II. Interested participants - including startups, MSMEs, academic institutions, PSUs, and individual innovators must register by filling out the Google Form with the following details:(only one team leader should fill the form)

- **Team Name**
- **Team Leader — Full Name and Email Address MOBILE NO**
- **Team Members** (Full Name | Role | Email | Mobile No.)

- **Organization Name and Type of Organization** (Startup, MSME, Academic/Research, Government, Industry Partner, or Other)
- **Project Proposal:** Brief description of the proposed AI solution, the problem addressed, research background, key features, development stage, technology stack, and primary thematic area (Generative AI, NLP, AI for Science, Emerging Technologies, or Other).
- **Technical Details:** Description of the proposed approach, datasets, compute requirements (GPU nodes, memory, storage, or datasets), and development maturity.
- **Supporting Documents & Declaration:** Upload of relevant project documentation, prior work, datasets, publications (if any), and a declaration confirming the authenticity of information provided.

III. The Team Leader will serve as the primary point of contact and is responsible for ensuring accurate and complete submission of all details.

IV. Once submitted, proposals will undergo evaluation by the Technical Review Committee comprising experts from academia, research, and industry.

V. Based on innovation potential, feasibility, and alignment with thematic areas, shortlisted teams will be notified via email and invited to participate in the next stage.

1.6.2. Participation in Solution Development and Testing

I. Shortlisted teams will receive an official communication from C-DAC (NPSF) with credentials and access instructions for the AIRAWAT AI Supercomputing Platform.

II. Each selected team will be granted free GPU compute credits for a limited duration (approximately three weeks) to develop and test their proposed AI solutions.

III. Teams will receive:

- User credentials for AIRAWAT access
- System usage documentation and guidelines
- Support on best effort basis from the system and application teams for setup and execution

IV. During this stage, teams must use the allocated compute time to train, optimize, and validate their AI models or workflows.

V. Teams will submit their final technical report, trained model, and short demonstration video through the submission link shared via email by **27 November 2025.**

1.6.3. Final Presentation at Proposed Event by CDAC

I. Teams successfully completing the compute phase (Stage 2) will be invited to present their developed solutions at the proposed event organized by CDAC, scheduled tentatively for 4–5 December 2025.

II. Each team will showcase their outcomes through a presentation and live demonstration before an expert jury comprising representatives from government, academia, and industry.

III. The top three teams will be recognized with cash prizes, certificates, and extended GPU compute credits for further development.

IV. Travel and accommodation support will be provided to the Team Leader (or one representative) of each shortlisted team for attending the physical workshop.

Key Notes:

- Incomplete or late submissions via the Google Form will not be considered.
- Participants are required to ensure originality and ethical use of data and models submitted.
- All submissions must adhere to the Code of Conduct and Rules & Guidelines shared in the official documentation.

1.7 Awards & Outcomes

The AI Innovation Challenge aims to recognize top-performing teams and encourage impactful AI development using the AIRAWAT Supercomputing Platform.

Prizes and Recognition:

- **1st Prize:** ₹2,00,000 + Certificate + GPU access credits on AIRAWAT
- **2nd Prize:** ₹1,50,000 + Certificate + GPU access credits on AIRAWAT
- **3rd Prize:** ₹1,00,000 + Certificate + GPU access credits on AIRAWAT

All shortlisted teams will also receive free GPU compute credits during the development phase and recognition certificates for their participation.

1.8 Intellectual Property Rights (IPR)

- Any new Intellectual Property (IP) created during the challenge will belong to the respective team
- C-DAC (MeitY) retains the right to use or deploy the developed solutions for public benefit with due credit to the creators.
- Teams are responsible for protecting their IP through institutional mechanisms.
- Participants must ensure all submitted materials comply with relevant data, copyright, and licensing standards

1.9 Code of Conduct

- Participants must uphold fairness, ethics, and integrity in AI research and development.
- Any misuse of AIRAWAT compute resources or violation of data and usage terms will lead to immediate disqualification and revocation of access.
- Teams are encouraged to propose their own problem statements within the thematic domains (Generative AI, NLP, AI for Science, Emerging Technologies, etc.) that align with India's national AI mission objectives.
- Collaboration, openness, and responsible use of AI technologies are expected from all participants.